

inaugural. Organized by the local Jewish Community Center, sixty boys and girls divided into four teams and played two games. For every batted ball, six or seven players tried to scoop up grounders in the infield and another six or seven ran to shag fly balls in the outfield. Teenage coaches pitched to each of the fifteen children on a team until he or she hit the ball. Innings ended after all kids had batted, regardless of the number of outs. The umpires made up rules based on each player's skill. For example, a little girl who hit and ran toward third instead of first was awarded another time at bat.

Our friend, Vicki, and I sat in the stands behind third base and watched the game. We cheered a little, and soon the kids started to make plays to third, in front of us, rather than to first. Our friend's son changed positions, from right field to third base, so we could see him in action. Base runners smiled and waved as they rounded third. This went on for a couple of innings until we realized why we were getting so much attention. We were the only adults there.

As we neared the end of the game a few parents came to pick up their kids. We could tell whose parent had arrived by watching whose face lit up. Once he had Dad's attention, Johnny started to cheer, hustle, and run after balls. We noticed that Dad, too, seemed to change from a sweaty, beaten executive into a smiling, proud father after watching a few minutes of play. And then it was over. The rest of the parents drove up, honked, packed up their kids, and headed off.

The game was played in a park about three miles from the San Francisco financial district. It started at 5:30 P.M. on a Tuesday, and I assumed several parents would make it. After all, it was their child's first-ever baseball game. Yet, not a single one of them did. The demands of the business day kept them glued to the office until 6:00 or 7:00 P.M.

A friend of mine has a 38-year-old son. Father and son are uncommonly close. One day the son told me why:

"When I was growing up my father was self-employed.